15 August 2026

CLIFF

Cambridge Lucy India Futures Forum

HARNESS

The CLIFF Newsletter



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1st issue

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The CLIFF Newsletter

Opening Note from the Editors

Welcome to the first issue of Harness, the newsletter of the Cambridge Lucy India Futures Forum (CLIFF).



Aditya Prasanna Bhattacharya
Research Assistant, CLIFF
Ph.D. candidate
Lucy Cavendish College

We chose 15 August deliberately. On this date seventy-nine years ago, India became an independent nation. It was the culmination of a struggle that drew on the deepest reserves of courage and imagination that a people can possess. Today, as India enters its eightieth year of independence, the relationship between India and the world is being remade, and Cambridge has a part to play in that remaking.



Dr Poorna Mysoor
Chair, CLIFF
Vice President,
Lucy Cavendish College

CLIFF was launched on 26 June 2026 at Lucy Cavendish College. It exists to deepen the engagement between Cambridge and India through student opportunity, research, partnerships, and public dialogue. It is young. Its best ideas are ahead of it. But the energy in the room on 26 June told us something: that there is an appetite for this idea, and that people are ready to build.

This first issue brings together voices from across the Cambridge-India landscape. We are honoured to carry notes from Professor Bhaskar Vira, Pro-Vice-Chancellor for Education and Environmental Sustainability at the University of Cambridge, and from Pratik Dattani, the founder of Bridge India. We look at the UK-India trade agreement that came into force just weeks after CLIFF was born from the eyes of Brishni Mukhopadhyay, finance professional with expertise in India-UK trade. We feature Dr Ira Chadha-Sridhar's pathbreaking work on care ethics. We look back at the CLIFF launch on 26 June and share a glimpse of what is coming next, including CLIFF's new Research Confluence series. We tell a small, unexpectedly human story about a young Jawaharlal Nehru, and we close with a book that traces the journey from Santiniketan to Trinity College and back again.

There is much to do. We hope you will do it with us.

The editors would like to thank Saumya Sheth, Part IB, Law Tripos, Lucy Cavendish College for her assistance in compiling this volume.

Friends of CLIFF



I am delighted to welcome the Cambridge Lucy India Futures Forum (CLIFF), an important initiative that strengthens the Collegiate University's engagement with India and complements the University's wider commitment to deepening partnerships through the Cambridge-India Centre for Advanced Studies (CAS). The launch of CLIFF reflects the strength and potential of the Cambridge-India relationship, building on a long shared history while creating new opportunities for collaboration, learning, and impact.

In particular, I warmly welcome Lucy Cavendish College's commitment to fostering partnerships with Indian institutions and expanding opportunities for student and staff mobility. These efforts will help deepen academic exchange, support the development of new research and educational collaborations, and strengthen our engagement with India's rapidly evolving knowledge economy and higher education landscape. By bringing together students, academics, alumni, and partners, CLIFF has the potential to make a significant contribution to the next chapter of the relationship between Cambridge and India.

Professor Bhaskar Vira FAcSS
Pro-Vice-Chancellor for Education & Environmental Sustainability
University of Cambridge



Beyond the government headlines, the best example for me, of the economic, people, ideas and cultural partnership between the countries is in Leicester Square: where you can find a bronze *Dilwale Dulhaniya Le Jayenge* statue, right next to Haldirams' first foreign outlet, and two hotels owned by an Indian entrepreneur who has been a leading job creator for Britain. 20 years ago, the partnership was aspirational but unrealised. The success of initiatives like CLIFF is important for the bilateral relationship to continue growing.

Pratik Dattani
Founder, Bridge India

Vantage Point *An expert's take on the UK-India CETA*



Brishni Mukhopadhyay

The India-UK Comprehensive Economic and Trade Agreement (CETA), signed in July 2025 and enforced on 15 July 2026, marks a significant milestone in bilateral relations. It is the UK's most significant bilateral trade deal since Brexit and India's most comprehensive agreement with a G7 economy. CETA has set an ambitious target of $100 billion in bilateral trade by 2030. Several verticals are of particular relevance to the CLIFF community.

Innovation

CETA places strong emphasis on innovation, providing a boost for sectors such as AI, deep tech, space technology and defence innovation. The deal strengthens government, industry, university and research collaboration through R&D, capacity building, technical cooperation and technology transfer, overseen by a new Innovation Working Group. Government procurement provisions also open UK public-sector digital and AI contracts to Indian bidders more equitably.

Healthcare

India has had a long history of sending GPs, specialists and medical practitioners within the NHS since its very inception. Healthcare and health-related professional services were both included among India's opened sub-sectors, and the sector benefits disproportionately from the mobility and mutual-recognition provisions. While the agreement in its current form stops short of a full mutual recognition of professional qualifications, CETA does create an opportunity for healthcare professionals in both countries for greater meaningful partnership.

Finance and Investment

CETA includes a dedicated Financial Services chapter that covers national treatment, most-favoured-nation treatment, market access, and prudential carve-outs. UK-based asset managers, insurers, and banks are likely to have greater legal certainty and continuity of access within Indian markets. The agreement is a foundation for deeper capital-markets engagement at a time that UK investors are actively looking to diversify allocations to India.

Legal Services

While the current iteration of CETA does not explicitly include further access for legal services, market access, trade and bilateral relationships across firms in both countries will result in opportunities for cross-border legal advice. CETA does offer improved transparency and mobility for legal process outsourcing, contract and compliance support services, and dispute-related professional services. Firms advising cross-border clients should treat this as unfinished business rather than a settled outcome.

Education

Education is one of the sub-sectors that provides opportunities through institutional partnerships and people. There is a clearer route to establish joint programmes, transnational education partnerships, and prospective campus presences in India. The formalisation of institutions to facilitate the exchange of ideas is crucial as students and professors embark on addressing the key challenges confronting society today.

CLIFF and CETA

CLIFF is ideally positioned to shape the dialogue at the college level by bringing together students to address these challenges. As one of the largest and most diverse colleges in terms of student population, Lucy Cavendish through CLIFF has the ability to partner with academia, the public and private sectors and transform students into future leaders who can implement the goals outlined in CETA. There is little doubt that CLIFF and Lucy Cavendish are ideally placed to deliver on the promise of CETA.

Brishni Mukhopadhyay is a finance professional and advisor with expertise in UK-India bilateral trade.

Basecamp *A student research showcase*

Dr Chadha-Sridhar works at the interface of law and philosophy, with a particular interest in the concept of care and the role of the law in shaping it. She works in the “ethics of care” tradition, an approach in moral philosophy with roots in critical feminist theory built around the idea that care is valuable and that its value has been neglected.



Dr Ira Chadha-Sridhar

Care ethics emerged in the early 1980s from feminist critiques of mainstream moral psychology. Its foundational text is Carol Gilligan's In a Different Voice (1982), which argued that women in empirical studies, when faced with moral dilemmas, foregrounded intimate relationships and the significance of caring for others. Since then, care ethics has faced serious challenges, most notably that it valorises the conditions of oppression it should be criticising.

Dr Chadha-Sridhar's research addresses these debates directly. She argues that care should be seen as a "thick ethical concept," combining description and evaluation, and that caring actions can be morally bad in virtue of the fact that they are caring. This allows care ethicists to better address prevalent criticisms.

The Indian legal and political context remains central to her work. In earlier research, she argued that Indian law needs a clearer account of who counts as a “carer,” and that care theory can help resolve persistent problems in Indian law governing maternity benefits. Her research agenda is most clearly exemplified in her forthcoming monograph, Care and the Mandate of Medical Law, to be published by Oxford University Press in 2027 as part of the Oxford Legal Philosophy series. The book offers a new account of medical negligence law rooted in a close philosophical analysis of the concept that underlies legal doctrine: care. The law of negligence is structured around the idea of care, yet there has been no sustained engagement between negligence doctrine and the ethics of care. The book fills that gap.

Dr Ira Chadha-Sridhar is an Assistant Professor in Law at the University of Warwick and was the Hatton-WYNG Junior Research Fellow in Law, Medicine and Life Sciences at Hughes Hall College. She holds a PhD (Law) from King's College and an LLM from Lucy Cavendish College, University of Cambridge.

Looking Back *The CLIFF launch - 26 June 2026*



On 26 June 2026, Lucy Cavendish College launched the Cambridge Lucy India Futures Forum. Dr Poorna Mysoor lit the lamp to mark an auspicious beginning. College President Girish Menon formally welcomed guests from across the University and beyond.

Bruno Cotta, CLIFF Vice Chair, spoke about the India opportunity for Cambridge. The student volunteers, Aditya Prasanna Bhattacharya and Aaryani Dogra, presented CLIFF's design principles and planned activities. Jo Ryan, Development Director, spoke about how the College plans to translate CLIFF's ambitions into action.

Professor Jaideep Prabhu, the Jawaharlal Nehru Professor of Indian Business and Enterprise, spoke about synergy and complementing existing efforts across Cambridge. Jeeves Rohilla, President (PG) of the Students' Union, made the case for student centricity. Shiraz Vira shared insights from running exchange programmes between the UK and India. Professor Nirmala Rao OBE, Vice Chancellor of Krea University, spoke about the leadership role that Lucy Cavendish has taken through this initiative.

The afternoon featured a reading from Nehru's *The Discovery of India*, a recital of Tagore's *Shobujer Obhijaan*, and a closing performance by the Cambridge University Indian Classical Music Society.

Guests included Professor Kamal Munir, Professor Shailaja Fennell, Dr Tamsyn Barton, alumni, supporters, and students from Trinity, Sidney Sussex, Christ's, St Edmund's, Murray Edwards, and from the Judge Business School, the Faculty of Law, and the Departments of Engineering, Mathematics, and Physics.

On the Horizon *What's next for CLIFF*

The CLIFF Confluence

Events are being planned and put together as you read this issue. Among the highlights include CLIFF's plans to host the CLIFF Confluence: a flagship event where academics, students, and practitioners from Cambridge, across the UK, and from India working across disciplines present their research on India in a lively, interactive format. Presenters will be in conversation with each other and with the audience, in a hybrid format open to participants joining from India and elsewhere.

Seminar Series

CLIFF plans to run smaller seminars throughout the year, in-person, online and hybrid. Each seminar will be focused on a narrower question within the broader India-facing research landscape. These will be designed to sustain the conversation between the termly gatherings and to give researchers a regular, low-barrier platform to share work in progress.

Strata *A layer of history*



Jawaharlal Nehru had come up to Trinity College, Cambridge, in 1907. He read Natural Sciences, graduating in 1910 with a Second. By 1911, he was in London, studying for the Bar at the Inns of Court. He was slim, well-dressed, quietly ambitious, and losing his hair.

The letter he wrote to his father Motilal that September is one of the most disarming documents in the Nehru archive. It is not about Indian self-governance. It is not about the Congress. It is about the state of his hair.

30 Gloucester Terrace W.
22. 9. 11

My dear Father,

. . . . The state of my head has certainly not improved lately. I think it is a little worse. I have been to the specialist twice and hope to go again in a short time. I don't suppose there is any chance of my getting back any of my lost hair. I may possibly be able to retain what little I have left. You need not trouble to send me any kind of oil. I detest using too much oil and I do not think it does much good. Nothing in the world will make hair grow if there are no roots left. All that the lotions can do is to keep the hair clean and prepare the way for any future growth. Kishan Bhai made me undergo his own particular treatment for a fortnight but it did not do me much good. I am getting rather fed up with my hair. The amount of time and money I have spent on it might have been utilised in a much better manner. .. .

With love,

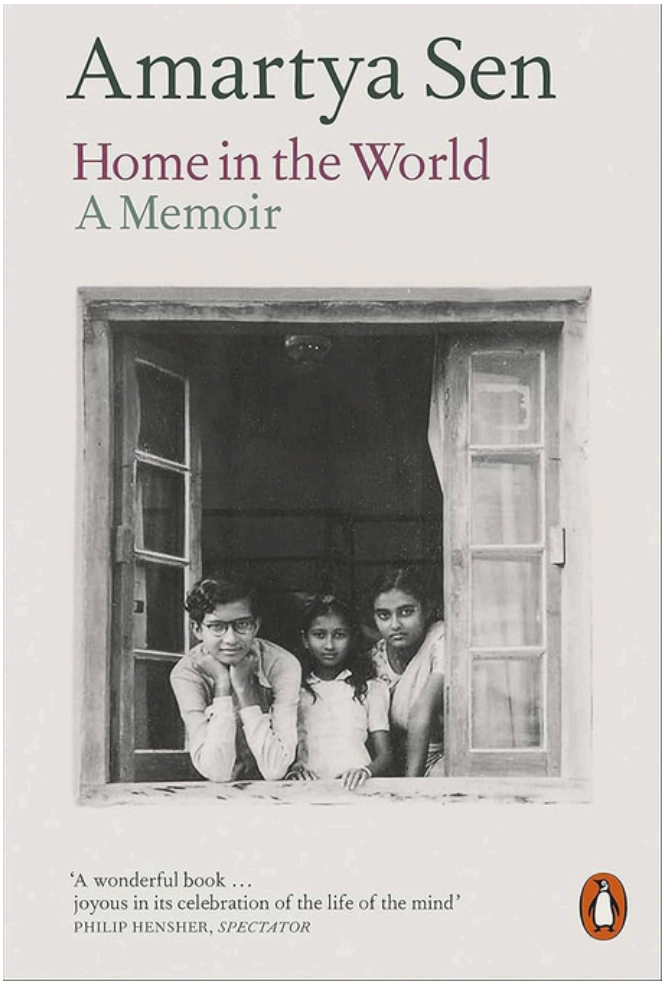
from your loving son
Jawahar

There is something wonderful about this letter. In 1911, the man who would go on to lead India was a young man in his twenties worrying about going bald. He was writing to his father the way any son would: a little plaintively, half-hoping for a solution and half-resigned to the fact that there probably was not one.

It is a reminder that the people who shaped history were, before anything else, people. They sat in rooms that were too cold, ate food that was not from home, worried about things that did not matter, and wrote letters to their parents about it. Here, young Jawahar was not yet Pandit Nehru. He was a student, he was far from home, and his hair was falling out.

Aditya Prasanna Bhattacharya

Off The Shelf *A book recommendation*



This is Amartya Sen's memoir, and it traces the exact geography that CLIFF occupies. It begins in Santiniketan, where Tagore ran his experimental school and where Sen grew up. Tagore personally chose the name "Amartya" for him. It moves through the Bengal famine of 1943, which Sen witnessed as a nine-year-old and which shaped the rest of his intellectual life.

It passes through Presidency College in Calcutta. It arrives at Trinity College, Cambridge, where Sen came as an undergraduate in 1953 and where he would later return as Master, the first Indian and Asian head of an Oxbridge college. Curiously, the President of Lucy Cavendish College, Girish Menon, is the second Indian to head an Oxbridge College!

The book is not an economics treatise. It reads like a conversation. Sen writes about arguments at the Coffee House in Kolkata, about cycling through Cambridge and discovering that intellectual life here could be informal, irreverent, and cross-disciplinary, and about how the famine he saw as a child became the question he spent his career answering.

Amartya Sen's life is a case study in what happens when a young person moves between India and Cambridge and lets both places work on him. He did not become less Indian at Trinity. He became a different kind of thinker because he held both worlds together. For a newsletter launching on Independence Day, this felt like the right note to end on.

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Rope Up *Getting Involved with CLIFF*

CLIFF belongs to its community. There are several ways to contribute to what we are building.

- **Support student scholarships and fellowships**
- **Sponsor public lectures and policy dialogues**
- **Partner on research initiatives**
- **Mentor students and early-career researchers**
- **Connect us with collaborators across academia, government, and industry**

Follow Lucy Cavendish College on Instagram & LinkedIn and email us to be added to our mailing list.



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